Nature, Origin & Characteristics of Language

Culture, language and communication: nature, origin and characteristics of language — with language, culture and thought

6 PYQs 2010 · 2015 · 2018 · 2019 · 2020 · 2025
+ 1993 note · origin once for 30M · language–culture–thought
in 4 of 7 · last asked 2025 (15M) · Mains Value **High**

THE ANSWER SPINE (1) A symbol system → (2) Design features → (3) Evolution: biological + cultural → (4) Culture and thought → (5) Language as method

(1) WHAT LANGUAGE IS

every answer opens here

Sapir 1921: "a purely human and non-instinctive method of communicating ideas, emotions and desires by means of a system of voluntarily produced symbols."

Saussure 1916: sign = signifier + signified; link **arbitrary**; **langue** (system) / **parole** (speech); meaning by difference.

Chomsky 1957/65: competence / performance; LAD; universal grammar; poverty of the stimulus.

Levels: phonology · morphology · syntax · semantics · pragmatics.
Boas: no "primitive" languages.

HOOK *A two-year-old understands "the purple elephant ate my homework" on first hearing — productivity.*

(2) CHARACTERISTICS — TESTED ON ANIMALS

Hockett 1960 + Altmann 1968

Ten to list: symbolic and arbitrary · rule-governed · **productive** · **displacement** · **duality of patterning** · **culturally transmitted** · social · dynamic · universal · reflexive.

- **Bee** (von Frisch) — nectar out of sight, only food.
- **Vervet** (Seyfarth, Cheney & Marler 1980) — leopard / eagle / snake calls; no "yesterday".
- **Signing apes** — Washoe, Koko, Kanzi: hundreds of signs.

HOOK *Washoe saw a swan and signed WATER BIRD — a new word? Terrace (1979), after Nim Chimpsky: mostly copying the teacher.*

Counter-case — Terrace 1979: no growth in sentence length, no syntax, few spontaneous questions. Apes: rich symbols, no productive grammar — **degree in symbols, kind in syntax**.

Line: no single feature is unique; the **combination** is.

Basis	Saussure 1916	Chomsky 1957/65
Pair	langue / parole	competence / performance
Lives in	the social system	the individual mind
Focus	sign; meaning by difference	syntax; generative rules
Anthro use	Lévi-Strauss, structuralism	universals; Hymes's critique (7-B)

Human vs animal, in words: animal systems are **closed, stimulus-bound, largely innate, single-level**; language is **open, displaced, learnt, doubly patterned**.

★ HERO — WHAT MAKES LANGUAGE HUMAN

draw for any answer

Design feature	Bee	Vervet	Ape (signs)	Human
Arbitrariness · semanticity	●	●	●	●
Discreteness	○	●	●	●
Displacement — the absent	◐	○	◐	●
Productivity — the never-heard	◐	○	◐	●
Duality — sounds → words	○	○	○	●
Cultural transmission	○	◐	◐	●
Prevarication · reflexiveness	○	○	◐	●

filled = present · half = partial or contested · open = absent
No animal system has the four gold rows together — that combination is language.

(3) ORIGIN — THE 2010 QUESTION

2010 · 30M "biological and cultural"

HOOK *c. 650 BCE: Psammetichus raised two babies in silence; they cried "bekos" (Phrygian, bread). In 1866 Paris banned the whole topic.*

Speculative — failed
bow-wow (imitation) · pooh-pooh (emotion) · ding-dong (resonance) · yo-he-ho (labour, Noiré) · la-la (play, Jespersen) · ta-ta (gesture, Paget). Untestable; words, not grammar.

Biological — capacity
larynx (Lieberman) · Kebara hyoid 1989 · breath control (MacLarnon 1999) · Broca 1861, Wernicke 1874 · **FOXP2** KE family 2001; Neanderthals 2007 · gesture-first (Rizzolatti & Arbib 1998; Corballis 2002) · gossip (Dunbar 1996) · protolanguage (Bickerton 1990) · Merge (Berwick & Chomsky 2016)

Cultural — use
labour (Engels 1876) · symbol: Blombos ochre c. 75 ka; Deacon 1997 · **Nicaraguan Sign Language**: deaf children build a language · creoles: children supply grammar · mono- vs polygenesis unresolved

HOOK *The KE family: three generations, one letter changed in FOXP2. Not "the language gene" — a gene for speech motor sequencing.*

When? Protolanguage with *H. erectus*; full syntax with *H. sapiens*, c. 200–100 ka (range 2 Ma–50 ka). **Line:** biology explains the capacity, culture the use — they co-evolved.

✎ EXAM OPENERS — HOOKS YOU CAN WRITE

first two lines of an answer

- **Origin:** "Psammetichus raised two infants in silence to find the first language; anthropology now asks the same question with evidence."
- **Sapir–Whorf:** "Whorf the fire inspector saw workers smoke beside 'empty' drums full of vapour — a word had shaped behaviour."
- **Characteristics:** "A bee can direct her sisters to nectar out of sight, but cannot tell them about yesterday — or lie."
- **Emic/etic:** "Hindi hears two sounds where English hears one — *phal* and *pal*; Pike built emic and etic on that difference."

(4) LANGUAGE, CULTURE AND THOUGHT

1993 · 2018 · 2020 · 2025 the core strand

HOOK *Whorf the fire inspector: workers smoked by "empty" petrol drums — empty of petrol, full of vapour. The word made them careless.*

Sapir 1929: people are at the mercy of their society's language. **Whorf 1940:** we dissect nature along lines laid down by our native languages.

STRONG — determinism | WEAK — relativity ✓ | UNIVERSALISM

Counter-cases: Hopi time refuted — Malotki 1983 · "Eskimo snow words" a hoax — Pullum 1991 · colour foci universal — Berlin & Kay 1969.

Support: Guugu Yimithirr compass terms — "an ant on your north leg" (Levinson 2003) · colour boundaries speed discrimination.

Culture → language: Nuer cattle colours · Hanunóo plants · Dravidian cross-cousin terms · *aap/tum/tu* · loanwords. Works on **vocabulary, pragmatics** more than syntax.

Position	Who
language part of culture; vary independently	Boas 1911
language determines thought	strong Whorf
language influences habitual thought	Sapir 1929; Levinson
culture elaborates vocabulary	Evans-Pritchard; Conklin
universal constraints	Chomsky; Berlin & Kay

Verdict: language is a lens, not a cage; influence runs both ways.

(5) LINGUISTICS ↔ ANTHROPOLOGY; INDIA

2015 · 2019 · 10M each

Language as subject (four fields) · **tool** (Malinowski 1922: fieldwork in the language) · **data** (kin, colour, plant terms) · **model** (phonology → Lévi-Strauss; Geertz's "text") · **history** (families; glottochronology, Swadesh).

HOOK *English hears the p in "pin" and "spin" as one sound; Hindi hears two — phal (fruit) vs pal (moment). Phonetic vs phonemic = etic vs emic (Pike 1954).*

HOOK *Jan 2010: Boa Sr, last speaker of Bo (Great Andamanese), died in Port Blair — she had spoken to birds for want of anyone else.*

India: four families + Andamanese · Census 2011: 121 languages, 22 scheduled · PLSI ~780 · NEP 2020 mother tongue "wherever possible".

1861–66
Broca's area; Paris bans origin debate

1911–21
Boas's Handbook; Saussure 1916; Sapir 1921

1954–60
Pike emic/etic; Chomsky 1957; Hockett 1960

1983–2010
Malotki 1983; FOXP2 2001; Boa Sr 2010

Traps: FOXP2 ≠ "language gene" · attack the strong Whorf, not the weak · emic/etic is Pike's · no "primitive" language.

THE VERDICT TO WRITE Language is at once a **biological capacity** (vocal tract, brain, FOXP2), a **cultural system** of arbitrary, doubly patterned, endlessly productive symbols, and a **social practice** learnt in community. No animal system combines its design features. Its origin is a story of gene–culture co-evolution, and its relation to thought is a lens, not a cage — culture shapes vocabulary, and language channels habitual attention, within limits set by universal human capacities.